DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

What Is Rosh Hashanah Really About?

Derech Hashem 2:8:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 8, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 23 August 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Back from the break, two weeks before Rosh Hashanah

The series resumed two weeks before Rosh Hashanah, after a review of Part 2 on hashgahah. Chapter 7 is about astrology ("for the Rambam you can wipe this whole chapter out, because astrology is nonsense"). The Rabbi decided to learn Chapter 8 first, because its first half is extremely relevant to Rosh Hashanah, and return to Chapter 7 afterwards, although ideally one learns in the Ramhal's order.

Hashgahah is strict justice

Chapter 8 gives several particular points about hashgahah, and the first, he said, "will change our Rosh Hashanah." The whole order of providence is straight justice (din). As the Gemara in Bava Kamma says, whoever says that HaKadosh Barukh Hu is a vatran, one who overlooks things, his life will be overlooked. "There's din." You cannot say, "God will forgive me." As the verses say, "the sceptre of Your kingdom is a sceptre of uprightness," and "a king establishes the land through justice."

That raises a problem. Yom Kippur we understand: according to the law I should be punished, but I did teshuvah, and teshuvah can transform my sins. But what is Rosh Hashanah about? We say that the shofar moves Hashem from the throne of judgement to the throne of mercy. What does that mean, if everything is justice?

Justice that comes from love

We learned in Part 1 that all Hashem wants is to bestow good, and He loves His creatures as a father loves his son. But any responsible parent knows that if you truly love your child, you discipline him. The Rabbi recalled the verse about a son of King David whose father never rebuked him, and what became of him. As the Torah says, as a man chastises his son, so Hashem chastises you.

Hashem's justice does not come from revenge or anger; it comes from love. A child who is never held accountable becomes lazy and unsuccessful. So too, if we had no accountability for

our actions we would not take life seriously and would end up, if lucky, with a very small portion. Difficulties are part of becoming the best we can be.

Two results of that love

The next paragraph, the last on page 82, "will explain the whole Rosh Hashanah." Because judgement comes from love, there are two results: - **The judgement is softened (memutak).** A father whose child runs into the road without looking must reprimand him. He can slap him in anger, "I've told you a hundred times," or take his hand, explain, and give a light tap to make him remember. Hashem must sometimes punish, but never from anger, so never harshly: just what we need to learn the lesson. - **Sometimes judgement is suspended entirely.** When the time calls for it, Hashem sets din aside and acts with mercy alone. "Vehanoti et asher ahon, verihamti et asher arahem": I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious. This, the Rabbi noted, is why that passage is read on fast days.

He illustrated the second with the same child. He has just done something dangerous and needs to be told off, but he comes with his sweet face and a funny comment, and "you just can't." You say, "I should really be punishing you, but I love you so much," and give him a big hug. That is hen, charm, from the same root as "vehanoti."

A participant compared it to being slow to anger. The Rabbi said this is far more than mitigation: "we're throwing the case out," like a judge who sees that the accused is his own child and cancels the case.

This is Rosh Hashanah

"This paragraph encapsulates Rosh Hashanah." The verse speaks of a father and his son. To be part of this you have to be in the picture as a child. When does a parent suspend judgement? When he sees how much the child loves him. Rosh Hashanah is about seeing Hashem as Melekh, being directly accountable to Him, and as one's Father, whom one loves.

That is why on Rosh Hashanah we do not focus on confessing sins or on personal requests. "You don't need to ask for things when all you have to do is just change the chair." The work of the day is to trigger the system of mercy, and then everything else falls into place. The Rabbi cited the Zohar comparing those who pray on Rosh Hashanah only for livelihood and life to dogs barking at their owners: a dog knows its owner but lacks the relationship of a child to a parent. The essence of the day is the shofar, with Malkhuyot, Zikhronot and Shofarot.

This also answers the famous question of why Yom Kippur comes after the judgement of Rosh Hashanah rather than before: on Rosh Hashanah, working through individual sins is a waste of time; all you need is to change the system from din to rahamim.

Two days, two stages

The Zohar says the first day of Rosh Hashanah is "dina kashya," harsh judgement, and the second "dina rafya," soft judgement. The Rabbi explained this through the Ramhal's two results. On day one we cannot leap straight to suspending judgement; the din is there, and we work to soften it, to be judged with kindness. On day two we try to weaken it completely, so that only mercy remains. "Nothing is happening, it's not the same thing happening in two

days... There's a whole progression." So no one should say, "I've done the first day, I don't need to come on the second."

He added that the first chapter of Bereshit uses only the name Elohim, the name of din: the world was created with din as the norm, with mercy added at times. A legal system in which police and judges usually overlook everything cannot work; but here and there they have discretion to let something go.

Page 83: mishpat and shelitah

Because Hashem wants us to choose freely, and for there to be justice, He created a world in which He has, as it were, subjected Himself to the system, like a father who could ignore what his child did but knows he must not. He is not bound by any law; He bound Himself. But when His wisdom decides to suspend din, He uses His exaltedness and sole authority: He passes over transgression and, more than overlooking, repairs the damage.

So there are two kinds of hashgahah. All we learned in the last seven chapters is the hashgahah of mishpat, justice, which is the norm. The second is the hashgahah of shelitah, His sole authority: "I am the supreme judge, and I decide I'm going to ignore everything." He uses it to sustain the world so that it is not destroyed by human evil.

A participant asked how this differs from calling Hashem a vatran. The Rabbi explained that vatran is a judge who, while judging, overlooks wrongdoing, which within a system of justice is absurd: "You can't come to court and say, the judge will be lenient on me." This is different: "the courts are closed." Like a parent who says, "I don't want to hear anything bad about my children." If a parent did that all the time the children would turn out terribly, but once in a while, after a great year, "I'm not hearing anything bad, I'm not punishing them for the next week." That is Rosh Hashanah. "If you didn't understand the shiur, listen to it again."

Summary

- Hashgahah is strict justice, but it comes from love, like a parent's discipline.
- Because of that love, judgement is always softened, and at certain times suspended entirely.
- Rosh Hashanah is about relating to Hashem as Father and King so that He moves from the throne of din to the throne of rahamim, not about lists of requests.
- The two days are two stages: first softening the judgement, then removing it.
- Page 83: besides the hashgahah of mishpat there is the hashgahah of shelitah, where Hashem sets the system aside; this is not "vatranut" but closing the court.

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